MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

# Block 2 — Unit 1: Poetry

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

## The chapter in one sentence

Four poetic works show how a journey, a wedding, and unusual comparisons can help us think about society and love.

## Start with a picture

A poem is not always a puzzle with a hidden password. First ask: Who is speaking? What is happening? What picture does the poem create? Only then ask what its language suggests.

## 1. Chaucer: General Prologue to The Canterbury Tales

### What happens?

It is spring, a season of renewal and travel. Pilgrims gather at the Tabard Inn in Southwark before travelling to the shrine of Thomas Becket at Canterbury. The Host, Harry Bailly, proposes a storytelling competition.

The pilgrimage is a **frame narrative**: a larger story that makes room for many smaller stories. Imagine classmates travelling on a bus and taking turns telling stories. The journey connects their different voices.

### How are the pilgrims presented?

Chaucer describes clothes, jobs, habits, manners, and values. These details do more than tell us what someone looks like.

| Pilgrim | Simple starting point | What to examine |
|---|---|---|
| Knight | Experienced soldier | Service, honour, and restraint |
| Squire | Young courtly man | Youth, appearance, and romance |
| Prioress | Religious woman with refined manners | Piety and social display |
| Monk | Religious man who enjoys worldly activities | Duty versus pleasure |
| Friar | Sociable religious figure | Money and religious responsibility |

| Pilgrim | Simple starting point | What to examine |
|---|---|---|
| Clerk | Poor, dedicated student | Love of learning |
| Wife of Bath | Experienced, outspoken woman | Marriage, authority, and gender |
| Parson and Ploughman | Devout pastor and honest worker | Faith expressed through conduct |
| Pardoner | Seller of pardons and relics | Religious language used for profit |

### Why does it matter?

**Satire** exposes faults; **irony** creates a gap between apparent praise and what readers notice. Chaucer's narrator can sound admiring while details encourage doubt. Do not assume the fictional narrator and the author are identical.

The poem offers a rich social picture, but it is not a complete census or a neutral photograph of medieval England.

## 2. Spenser: Prothalamion

### What happens?

A troubled speaker walks beside the Thames. Flowers, nymphs, and two swans create a beautiful scene connected with the coming double marriage of Elizabeth and Katherine Somerset. The swans represent the brides.

The poem moves from a pastoral riverside scene towards London and an aristocratic social world. Its repeated request that the Thames flow softly gives the celebration musical unity.

### What should you notice?

- **Wedding celebration:** beauty, hope, and harmony.
- **Pastoral imagery:** flowers, water, and nymphs.
- **Refrain:** a repeated line holds the poem together.
- **Personal and political context:** the speaker's disappointment and courtly connections remain present beneath the celebration.

A useful picture is a wedding song whose singer also quietly remembers personal worries.

## 3. Donne: The Canonization

### What happens?

The speaker answers someone who criticises his love. He says that the lovers harm nobody and should be left alone. He then imagines poetry preserving them as "saints" of love.

**Canonization** normally means declaring someone a saint. Donne transfers that religious language to lovers. This is a daring poetic argument, not a literal account of a religious ceremony.

### How does the argument grow?

First comes resistance to criticism; then the claim that love causes no public harm; then extravagant images of the lovers' shared life; finally, the idea that poems can preserve their example. Images such as the phoenix connect destruction and renewal.

The important question is how private love gains an importance that rivals public honour.

## 4. Donne: A Valediction: Forbidding Mourning

### What happens?

A speaker asks his beloved to face their separation calmly. Their connection is spiritual and lasting, so physical distance need not destroy it.

### Two images to understand

**Gold:** it can be beaten very thin without breaking. Separation can be imagined as extension rather than rupture.

**Drawing compass:** the two legs remain connected. One moves around while the other provides a steady centre. This is a **conceit**, an extended comparison explaining unity across distance.

The speaker contrasts noisy public displays of grief with quiet confidence. This is the poem's argument about love, not a rule that real people must never cry.

## Build an exam answer

For each poem, use: situation → central image → literary technique → meaning. For example: separation → compass → conceit → emotional unity despite physical distance.

## Quick check

1. What holds *The Canterbury Tales* together? **The pilgrimage and storytelling arrangement.**
2. What do the two swans suggest? **The two brides.**
3. Are Donne's lovers literally made saints? **No; religious language becomes a metaphor for their love.**
4. Why is the compass useful? **Its connected legs picture separation within continuing unity.**

## Develop an exam answer

### Practice question

How do the selected poems connect private feeling with wider social meanings?

## Expanded discussion

The General Prologue turns a religious journey into an arrangement through which social differences become visible. Chaucer’s pilgrims are distinguished by occupation, appearance, habits, and speech. Yet these details do not constitute a neutral inventory. They guide readers towards questions about duty and conduct, particularly where a figure’s worldly pleasures conflict with a religious role. The frame narrative also gives social difference a dramatic dimension, because travellers must listen and respond to one another.

Prothalamion combines a wedding celebration with a speaker’s awareness of courtly disappointment and public belonging. Its natural images create an atmosphere of harmony, while its movement towards London places that harmony within an aristocratic social world. The two swans and the repeated address to the Thames give the poem unity. The wedding subject therefore does not exclude personal frustration or public aspiration; the poem holds these concerns together.

Donne’s poems make private love the subject of intellectual argument. In The Canonization, the speaker responds to criticism by imagining the lovers’ preservation as exemplary figures through poetry. Religious vocabulary gives intimate experience a startling authority. In A Valediction, the compass and beaten gold argue that physical separation need not destroy spiritual unity. These are not random ornaments: each comparison helps develop a claim about the nature and value of love.

## Suggested answer structure

1. Identify each poem’s situation
2. Chaucer: social detail and irony
3. Spenser: imagery, refrain, and courtly context
4. Donne: religious language and conceits
5. Compare public and private values

## Common mistakes to avoid

For a question on one poem, develop that poem alone. Do not substitute a summary of all four works for close analysis of the selected text.

## Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.